Augmenting vs Substituting

The use of AI has become a burning question, especailly in companies and job markets: What should AI be doing? AI systems have grown enough to almost replace humans in certain tasks, and such innovation has come with the dilemma of how much to let AI do for humans. The use of AI can be categorized into two: Augmenting and Substituting.

Augmenting

The use of AI to enhance decision making and operative capabilities without replacing human labor.

Augmenting can look like delegating smaller, repetitive, and less important tasks that do not require human thinking to alleviate the workload of human thinkers so that they can focus on the important aspects. When augmenting, humans remain as a key component of the process, meaning that humans ensure that there is empathy, fairness and accountability in the judgements that are being made.

Substituting

The use of AI to replace meaningful human thinking and human operations completely. Substituting can look like giving full control or most control over a process, decision or project. Though there may be minor moderations done by humans, most of the thinking is done by AI.

In the context of a classroom environment, augmenting could be:

- using AI to find sources that they can then look into and verify, instead of directly asking for information
- using AI as a debate partner to challenge ideas and strengthen arguments
- using AI to brainstorm initial ideas that the student then builds upon and adapts to their own creative directive

In the context of a classroom environment, substituting could be:

- asking AI to write an essay
- asking AI to summarize and analyze a book that the student was assigned to read and annotate
- using information and sources given to them by AI without verifying or looking at the sources themselves

However, the line dividing Augmenting and Substituting is blurred, and the definition may vary from person from person.

Job Market

In the past few years, the issue of AI replacing humans in the workplace has risen signficantly. The answer to this is still ambiguous. Some people say that AI will replace humans completely, and the need to work will disappear, others claim that something are not replaceable, and some say that new job markets will arise.

Though the answer is still a gray area, it is undeniable that AI will effect the job market one way or another, and AI will become an integral part of the workplace. It is important to make the distinction between augmenting and substituting when using AI to prevent the atrophy of critical thinking that will be essential in a world of AI.